



What Happens after UNIFIL?

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A year ago, on
August 28, 2025,
the UN Security

Peacekeepers serving with the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) patrol along the Blue Line between Ras Naqoura and Labounieh, April 8, 2024. UN Photo/Pasqual Gorriz

Council decided to close the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), a large UN peacekeeping mission that has been stationed in southern Lebanon for nearly 50 years. What little attention this decision attracted at the time was almost immediately overtaken by the announcement of the US 20-Point Plan for Gaza and the creation of the Board of Peace, and later by the outbreak of the Iran war.

Yet the withdrawal of thousands of international peacekeepers, set to begin at the end of UNIFIL's current mandate on December 31, 2026, risks leaving a political, security, and economic vacuum in one of the most volatile corners of the Middle East that will be difficult to fill. Worryingly, one year on from the Security Council's decision, and with the end of the mission's mandate only months away, there is not yet an agreed plan for what happens after UNIFIL leaves. Without one, southern Lebanon could become the center of another phase of regional instability.

UNIFIL's Stabilizing Effect

UNIFIL was first deployed to southern Lebanon in 1978 to restore peace and security, confirm Israel's withdrawal following its actions against the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), and support the return of Lebanese state authority to the area. Between 1982 and 2000, the Israel Defense Forces (IDF) returned to Lebanon and established a long-term presence in the south. During this period, UN peacekeepers frequently came under IDF fire but continued to operate as best they could, including by providing assistance and protection to local communities. In the aftermath of the 2006 war between Israel and Hizbullah, UNIFIL's strength was boosted with additional troops and a maritime interdiction force to support a ceasefire that lasted for 17 years until the start of Hizbullah's sustained offensive against Israel on October 8, 2023.[1] At peak levels of deployment, UNIFIL had some 12,500 international military personnel south of the Litani River, and 18 naval vessels patrolling Lebanese waters. Currently, 47 member states contribute to the mission.

Because from the outset UNIFIL did not receive a clear mandate to use force to enforce the 2006 ceasefire, it would never meet Israeli demands to provide a watertight security guarantee against Hizbullah attacks or incursions into northern Israel, nor to disarm Hizbullah.[2] For the same reason, UNIFIL was unable to meet Lebanese expectations of preventing Israeli violations of Lebanon's airspace, periodic strikes, or a

complete Israeli withdrawal from small pockets of Lebanese territory. In these critical respects, UNIFIL's hands were tied by Security Council members and troop-contributing countries. But despite its shortcomings, the mission has served as a stabilizer in at least three important ways.

One was that UNIFIL developed a complex management regime around the 2006 ceasefire, without which it might not have lasted the 17 years that it did. This involved maintaining UN observation posts along the Israel–Lebanon demarcation line (Blue Line), standing up checkpoints and conducting mobile patrols, and impartially monitoring and regularly reporting violations for the Security Council to consider and act upon. UNIFIL also liaised with the IDF and the Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF) and used its political and civil affairs units to interact with de facto local authorities in Hizbullah's core area of influence. Under the good offices of the UN secretary-general, UNIFIL hosted face-to-face meetings between IDF and LAF officers. These mechanisms made it possible for both sides to exchange information and messages and clarify their intentions, lowering or averting the risk of misunderstandings and cross-border escalations. Although the ceasefire was regularly breached, the presence of UN channels of communication and reporting helped ensure a level of stability and continuity that allowed communities on both sides of the Blue Line to live in relative security.

UNIFIL's second stabilizing function was political, and internal to Lebanon itself. By deploying several thousand international troops into Hizbullah's heartland in the south, UNIFIL largely absolved a weak and unprepared Lebanese state of its own responsibility to deploy forces to the region. The political effect was to "delay the impossible" by providing an open-ended formula for Lebanese leaders to postpone the potentially fatal decision of confronting and disarming Hizbullah at a time when no other domestic military force could challenge the militia. For UNIFIL's critics, this amounted to protecting Hizbullah and giving the group time to become more powerful. For its supporters, this was about maintaining confessional coexistence and avoiding a new civil conflict inside Lebanon. Because both views contain an element of truth, this developed into an enduring catch-22 that many recognized but that had no immediate alternative. Its overall effect was to stabilize political dynamics in Lebanon for a protracted ceasefire period.

Third, UNIFIL was by far the largest, steadiest single employer and a key socioeconomic driver in one of Lebanon's historically most deprived areas. In addition to employing hundreds of locally recruited civilian staff with stable salaries, UNIFIL was also a primary client for local merchants and service providers, ranging from construction workers to tailors and food suppliers.[3] Over nearly 50 years, hundreds of local businesses and communities benefited from UNIFIL's economic stimulus, healthcare services, roadworks, and municipal improvement projects. Arguably, this also implied an economic modus vivendi with Hizbullah, the primary political force in the south. But it helped decisively stabilize a historically depressed and potentially restive area of Lebanon, and to a degree shielded southern communities from the worst effects of the economic crisis that broke out in 2019. UNIFIL's planned departure raises serious questions about how to manage an inevitable economic transition in southern Lebanon, particularly for youth, including young men.

What Happens Next?

Several troop-contributing countries have already begun withdrawing their forces from UNIFIL in anticipation of the end of its mandate in December. But with Israel now occupying much of the mission's area of operations in southern Lebanon, what comes after its full drawdown is a matter of heated disagreement in the Security Council and in the region itself.[4] Despite a fast-approaching deadline, there is no plan on how to fill the impending gap. In the absence of a plan, we are left to consider possible ways forward and the challenges they face.

The best way forward would involve a voluntary "national agreement" between Hizbullah and Lebanon's other political parties whereby Hizbullah would decommission its fighters and weapons and incorporate them into Lebanon's regular army. While Hizbullah would continue to exist as a political party, it would cease to operate as an independent armed force. This would arguably amount to the most fundamental, and most awaited, shift in Lebanon's domestic politics since the end of its civil war in 1990.[5] Were this course to open a new phase of peaceful confessional coexistence inside Lebanon while providing sufficient security guarantees for Israel, it would provide a long-desired, fully Lebanese-led solution for placing southern Lebanon under state control and setting the stage for an orderly exit by UNIFIL. However, this would require Hizbullah to give up not just its weapons but also its foundational identity as a resistance movement against Israel and to definitively sever its independent ties with Iran. Given the current Iran war and Hizbullah's role in it, as well as Israel's renewed presence in southern Lebanon, this is unlikely to occur before the end of UNIFIL's mandate.

A second possibility would involve maintaining an international force under an agreed formula. Lebanon has communicated a joint letter from 86 members of its parliament to the Security Council to delay UNIFIL's withdrawal, a position also now reportedly held by some Council members, including China. UN Secretary-General António Guterres has proposed options for a reduced force of UN observers to monitor the area between the Litani River and the Blue Line. A continued UN presence would have the benefit of familiarity with both the Lebanese army and local communities and would maintain direct engagement by the Security Council. But Israel's appetite for a new UN presence in southern Lebanon, and that of the US, is in serious doubt. For its part, France, a historical contributor to UNIFIL, has made clear that it wishes to maintain a military foothold in Lebanon and, together with Italy, has announced its intention to propose a new intervention force, possibly with a looser link to the UN and coordinated with the EU and NATO. Türkiye has likewise signaled that it wishes to contribute to an international security force to replace UNIFIL. Yet while these initiatives have been welcomed by Lebanon, Israel's strained relationship with France, and particularly with Türkiye, would severely complicate any actual deployments.

Third, there is the trilateral US–Israel–Lebanon formula currently underway in the context of ongoing ceasefire discussions dating back to April 2026. Borrowing aspects from the Board of Peace process being attempted in Gaza, the Lebanese army is being both pushed and supported to clear Hizbullah positions, weapons, and personnel from “pilot zones” in southern Lebanon in exchange for a phased Israeli withdrawal. But unlike Hamas in Gaza, Hizbullah is not party to this initiative and, predictably, has refused to give up its weapons unless Israel fully withdraws from Lebanon. Meanwhile, the simultaneous presence of the IDF and the Lebanese army in the south has already led to incidents between the two. These realities point to a slow and possibly inconclusive pilot phase. Critically, given historical divisions inside Lebanon, it is unclear how far the Lebanese army can push Hizbullah without triggering a new phase of civil instability or conflict.

Finally, in the absence of any workable national or international formula, there is the looming prospect of a long-term, open-ended Israeli presence in southern Lebanon in the form of a security cordon. This would be a return to the past, and, as with Israel's earlier occupation, it would sever southern Lebanon from the rest of the country and constitute an enduring breach of Lebanese sovereignty. As such, it would create new justifications and motivations for the ideology and actions of resistance.

Conclusion

Whether UNIFIL was, on the whole, a successful peacekeeping mission will likely be a subject of enduring debate. But during the 17-year ceasefire following 2006, it performed valuable internal and cross-border stabilizing functions in a critical and highly volatile place. Such functions will continue to be required, yet finding a post-UNIFIL formula remains a challenge amid conflicting perceptions, positions, and interests.

Historically, from the Suez Crisis onward, UN peacekeeping has been used as a stabilizing instrument precisely in situations where member states or domestic forces have been unable to agree on peaceful outcomes. Under the pressure of time, in the absence of agreed alternatives, and as a matter of prudence, the Security Council may yet consider the option of a modified UN presence before UNIFIL's mandate expires. It would do so, likely over Israeli objections, by voting to retain a reduced UNIFIL or by authorizing a new, smaller UN observer mission. A new mandate that acknowledges the US–Israel–Lebanon initiative and seek ways to support it would, at the very least, open a door to positive US engagement, offering independent monitoring and verification and time-tested political and civil affairs experience in ongoing US efforts to mediate and facilitate the Lebanese army's entry into the south and providing humanitarian assistance to local communities.

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[1] The Security Council called for a cessation of hostilities in Resolution 1701 (2006). Despite the onset of hostilities in October 2023, the resolution formally remains in place, now in its 20th year.

[2] The ambiguous formulation of paragraph 12 of Resolution 1701 enabled troop-contributing states to adopt a strictly defensive operational posture. See UN Doc. /2011/715.

[3] According to the UN secretary-general's report on UNIFIL personnel deployments, the mission employed 600 local staff as of June 2026.

[4] Despite severe operational disruptions due to insecurity and movement restrictions, UNIFIL continues to conduct patrols where possible, to report information to the Security Council, and to assist local communities.

[5] The dissolution of all domestic and foreign-backed armed militias in Lebanon was provided for in section 2 of the 1989 [Taif Agreement](#), a quasi-constitutional document that formally ended Lebanon’s civil war in 1990.

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